

Minimal winding in the self-similar collapse of three point vortices and of two concentric vortex polygons

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Abstract. In a self-similar collapse of point vortices every vortex moves on a logarithmic spiral, and the dimensionless number $P = |\omega_0| t_c$, the initial angular velocity times the collapse time, measures how tightly the spiral winds. We minimize P over two classical collapsing families. Every collapse of three point vortices can be normalized to circulations $(1, \mu, -\mu/(1+\mu))$ with $0 < \mu \leq 1$ and zero angular impulse. For each μ the collapsing configurations form two arcs, one for each orientation of the vortex triangle, and P has exactly one critical point, a minimum, on each. The squares of the two minima are roots of an explicit cubic whose coefficients are polynomials in μ , and for $\mu < 1$ the two minima differ. The smaller one increases strictly from $\sqrt{3}/2$, approached as $\mu \rightarrow 0$, to $\sqrt{2}$ at $\mu = 1$. Hence $P > \sqrt{3}/2$ for every collapse of three point vortices, and the constant is sharp; equivalently, every vortex travels more than twice its initial distance from the collision point. For $\mu = 1/2$ the two minima are 1.0647059762... and 2.2038550160..., the positive roots of $8748x^6 - 49005x^4 + 27794x^2 + 18723$, and they are not expressible by real radicals. For two concentric regular n -gons with circulations x_n and -1 , $P = (K_n - \sqrt{2n-1} \cos n\theta)/(2n \sin n\theta)$ in terms of the relative rotation θ , with an explicit constant K_n , and the minimum over θ is $\sqrt{K_n^2 - 2n + 1}/(2n)$; for pentagons it is $\sqrt{31682}/80$. The results are proved, and they are checked against the Biot-Savart velocities in high-precision arithmetic.

Keywords: point vortices; vortex collapse; self-similar motion; logarithmic spiral.

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1. Introduction

Three point vortices can collapse to a point in finite time only if $1/\Gamma_1 + 1/\Gamma_2 + 1/\Gamma_3 = 0$ and their angular impulse about the center of vorticity vanishes, and under these conditions the motion is self-similar: the vortex triangle keeps its shape while it shrinks and rotates [1, 9]. Such collapse was found by Gröbli [7] and found again by Aref [1] and by Novikov and Sedov [12], who also constructed collapsing configurations of four and five vortices; see [4] for the history and [11] for the general theory. Aref [3] gave the collapse rate and the rotation frequency for general circulations, and Gotoda [6] gave explicit formulas for the self-similar motions of three vortices. Collapse also occurs in configurations of higher symmetry. Aref [2] reduced the motion of two concentric regular n -gons of vortices to an integrable Hamiltonian system with two degrees of freedom, and Koiller et al. [8] found collapsing configurations of two such rings, whose vortices move on logarithmic spirals.

In a self-similar collapse at time t_c the configuration has rotated by time t through the angle $-\omega_0 t_c \ln(1 - t/t_c)$, where ω_0 is the initial angular velocity. The angular velocity at time t is $\omega_0 t_c / (t_c - t)$, so the product of the angular velocity and the remaining time does not depend on which instant is taken as initial. Each vortex moves on a logarithmic spiral about the collision point, and the dimensionless number $P = |\omega_0| t_c$, which is invariant under rescaling of lengths, times and circulations, is the angle through which the configuration turns while the square of its

size decreases by the factor e . Equivalently, the path of each vortex makes the constant angle $\arctan 2P$ with the direction to the collision point, and a vortex that starts at distance r_0 from that point travels the distance $r_0\sqrt{1+4P^2}$ before the collapse. Within a collapsing family it is natural to ask which configuration winds least.

For three vortices we answer this question completely (Section 3). After normalization the circulations are $(1, \mu, -\mu/(1+\mu))$ with $0 < \mu \leq 1$. The collapsing configurations form two arcs, one for each orientation of the triangle, and P has a unique minimum on each (Theorem 1). For $\mu < 1$ the two minima differ, and the smaller one increases strictly with μ , from $\sqrt{3}/2$ as $\mu \rightarrow 0$ to $\sqrt{2}$ at $\mu = 1$, the value for two equal circulations. Thus $P > \sqrt{3}/2$ for every collapse of three vortices, and the bound is sharp (Corollary 1). For $\mu = 1/2$ the two minima are conjugate algebraic numbers of degree six, given explicitly in Proposition 1. In Section 4 we treat two concentric regular n -gons, for which the minimization reduces to an elementary inequality once P is written in a suitable form. Section 5 describes an independent numerical check.

2. Self-similar collapse

The positions $z_j \in \mathbb{C}$ of point vortices with circulations Γ_j evolve according to

$$\dot{\bar{z}}_j = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \sum_{k \neq j} \frac{\Gamma_k}{z_j - z_k}. \quad (1)$$

Suppose $\sum_j \Gamma_j \neq 0$, let $z_c = \sum_j \Gamma_j z_j / \sum_j \Gamma_j$ be the center of vorticity, which is conserved, and suppose that at $t = 0$ there is $\kappa \in \mathbb{C}$ with $\dot{z}_j = \kappa(z_j - z_c)$ for all j . The right-hand side of (1) is homogeneous of degree -1 in the relative positions and equivariant under rotations, so the solution is $z_j(t) = z_c + \lambda(t)e^{i\varphi(t)}(z_j(0) - z_c)$ with $\lambda\dot{\lambda} = \operatorname{Re} \kappa$ and $\lambda^2\dot{\varphi} = \operatorname{Im} \kappa$. Hence $\lambda^2 = 1 + 2t \operatorname{Re} \kappa$. If $\operatorname{Re} \kappa < 0$ the vortices collide at z_c at the time $t_c = -1/(2 \operatorname{Re} \kappa)$, and $\omega_0 = \operatorname{Im} \kappa$, so that

$$P = |\omega_0| t_c = \frac{|\operatorname{Im} \kappa|}{-2 \operatorname{Re} \kappa}. \quad (2)$$

Integrating $\dot{\varphi} = \omega_0/\lambda^2$ gives $\varphi = -P \ln \lambda^2$ when $\omega_0 > 0$, which is the description of the spiral given in the introduction. The angular impulse about the center of vorticity satisfies

$$\sum_j \Gamma_j |z_j - z_c|^2 = \frac{1}{\sum_j \Gamma_j} \sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k |z_j - z_k|^2. \quad (3)$$

It is conserved and, in a self-similar motion, proportional to λ^2 , so it must vanish for a collapse. Two of the minimizations below (Remark 2 and Proposition 2) reduce to the following elementary inequality.

Lemma 1. *Let $a > |b|$. For $0 < \alpha < \pi$, $(a - b \cos \alpha)/\sin \alpha \geq \sqrt{a^2 - b^2}$, with equality if and only if $\cos \alpha = b/a$.*

Proof. The numerator is positive, and $(a - b \cos \alpha)^2 - (a^2 - b^2) \sin^2 \alpha = (a \cos \alpha - b)^2$. $\square$

3. Three vortices

3.1. Normalization and the collapsing configurations

By the necessary conditions recalled in the introduction, two of the three circulations of a collapsing configuration have the same sign. Multiplying all circulations by a positive constant rescales time and leaves P unchanged. Multiplying them by -1 reverses time, and so does complex conjugation of the positions, which maps solutions of (1) to solutions; the composition maps collapsing solutions to collapsing solutions with the same P . After relabeling we may therefore assume

$$\Gamma = \left(1, \mu, -\frac{\mu}{1+\mu}\right), \quad 0 < \mu \leq 1. \quad (4)$$

Then $\sum_j \Gamma_j = R/(1+\mu) > 0$, where $R = 1 + \mu + \mu^2$. For $w = (z_3 - z_1)/(z_2 - z_1)$ the sum $\sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k |z_j - z_k|^2$ in (3) equals $\mu(1+\mu)^{-1} |z_2 - z_1|^2 (1 + 2\mu \operatorname{Re} w - (1+\mu)|w|^2)$, which vanishes exactly on the circle $|w - \mu/(1+\mu)| = \sqrt{R}/(1+\mu)$. We use a parametrization of the zero-impulse configurations equivalent to that of Gotoda [6, Sect. 3]:

$$z_1 = \frac{\mu(1 + \sqrt{R}e^{-i\theta})}{(1+\mu)^2}, \quad z_2 = \frac{\mu - \sqrt{R}e^{-i\theta}}{(1+\mu)^2}, \quad z_3 = 1, \quad \theta \in [0, 2\pi). \quad (5)$$

Here $\sum_j \Gamma_j z_j = 0$, so $z_c = 0$, and

$$z_1 - z_2 = \frac{\sqrt{R}e^{-i\theta}}{1+\mu}, \quad z_3 - z_1 = \frac{\sqrt{R}(\sqrt{R} - \mu e^{-i\theta})}{(1+\mu)^2}, \quad z_3 - z_2 = \frac{\sqrt{R}(\sqrt{R} + e^{-i\theta})}{(1+\mu)^2}. \quad (6)$$

The shape ratio is $w = \mu/(1+\mu) - (\sqrt{R}/(1+\mu))e^{i\theta}$, which traverses the zero-impulse circle exactly once, so every zero-impulse configuration is obtained, up to translation, rotation and dilation, for exactly one θ . Since $\operatorname{Im} w = -(\sqrt{R}/(1+\mu))\sin\theta$, the triangle $z_1 z_2 z_3$ is negatively oriented for $\sin\theta > 0$ and positively oriented for $\sin\theta < 0$. Put $C = \sqrt{R}\cos\theta$ and

$$N(C) = 2(1+\mu^2)R + (1-\mu)(2+\mu+2\mu^2)C - 2\mu C^2, \quad M(C) = 1 - \mu + 2C. \quad (7)$$

Lemma 2. *For every θ the three quotients $\dot{z}_j/(z_j - z_c)$ are equal to*

$$\kappa = \frac{i(1+\mu)^3}{2\pi\sqrt{R}} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{R} + (1-\mu)e^{i\theta}}{(\sqrt{R} - \mu e^{i\theta})(\sqrt{R} + e^{i\theta})}, \quad (8)$$

and, with $D = (R + \mu^2 - 2\mu C)(R + 1 + 2C) > 0$,

$$\operatorname{Re} \kappa = -\frac{(1+\mu)^3 \mu M(C) \sin\theta}{2\pi\sqrt{R}D}, \quad \operatorname{Im} \kappa = \frac{(1+\mu)^3 N(C)}{2\pi R D}. \quad (9)$$

Moreover $N(C) > 0$ for every θ .

Proof. Since $z_c = 0$ and $z_3 = 1$, $\kappa = \dot{z}_3$, and by (1), $\dot{z}_3 = (2\pi i)^{-1}((z_3 - z_1)^{-1} + \mu(z_3 - z_2)^{-1})$. Inserting the differences above gives the stated κ . The same computation for $j = 1$ and $j = 2$ gives the same value, as it must, since these configurations move self-similarly [9]. The real and imaginary parts follow on multiplying numerator and denominator by the complex conjugate of the denominator, since $|\sqrt{R} - \mu e^{i\theta}|^2 |\sqrt{R} + e^{i\theta}|^2 = D$. The two factors of D are at least $(\sqrt{R} - \mu)^2$

and $(\sqrt{R}-1)^2$, which are positive because $R > \mu^2$ and $R > 1$. Finally, N is concave in C , and $N(\sqrt{R})N(-\sqrt{R}) = 3\mu^2(1+\mu)^2R$ and $N(\sqrt{R}) + N(-\sqrt{R}) = 4R(1-\mu+\mu^2)$ are positive, so $N > 0$ on $|C| \leq \sqrt{R}$. $\square$

By Lemma 2 every zero-impulse configuration rotates in the positive sense, and it collapses exactly when $M(C)\sin\theta > 0$. Let $\theta_0 \in (0, \pi)$ be defined by $\cos\theta_0 = (\mu-1)/(2\sqrt{R})$. The configurations with $\theta = 0$ and $\theta = \pi$ are collinear, and those with $\theta = \pm\theta_0$ are equilateral triangles; these four are relative equilibria. The collapsing configurations form the two arcs

$$\mathcal{A}_+ = (0, \theta_0), \quad \mathcal{A}_- = (\pi, 2\pi - \theta_0), \quad (10)$$

the triangle being negatively oriented on $\mathcal{A}_+$ and positively oriented on $\mathcal{A}_-$, and on them (2) gives

$$P(\theta) = \frac{N(C)}{2\mu\sqrt{R}M(C)\sin\theta}, \quad C = \sqrt{R}\cos\theta. \quad (11)$$

Since $z_j(-\theta) = \overline{z_j(\theta)}$, the reflection $\theta \rightarrow -\theta$ maps $\mathcal{A}_+$ and $\mathcal{A}_-$ onto the expanding arcs $(2\pi - \theta_0, 2\pi)$ and (θ_0, π) .

3.2. The minimal winding

Let $u = \mu + 1 + 1/\mu \geq 3$ and $Q(\mu, y) = \mu^6 \tilde{Q}(u, y)$, where

$$\begin{aligned} \tilde{Q}(u, y) = & 1728(u+1)^2 y^3 - 144(u+1)(8u^3 - 9u - 9)y^2 \\ & - 4(16u^6 - 288u^4 - 288u^3 - 81u^2 - 162u - 81)y + 3(4u^3 - 3u - 3)^2. \end{aligned} \quad (12)$$

Then Q is a polynomial in μ and y with integer coefficients, irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$. Its discriminant with respect to y is

$$28311552\mu^4(\mu-1)^2(\mu+1)^4(\mu+2)^2(2\mu+1)^2R^6B^3, \quad (13)$$

where $B = 4\mu^6 + 12\mu^5 + 51\mu^4 + 82\mu^3 + 51\mu^2 + 12\mu + 4$; the sum of its roots is $(8u^3 - 9u - 9)/(12(u+1)) > 0$, and their product is $-((4u^3 - 3u - 3)/(24(u+1)))^2 < 0$. Hence for $0 < \mu < 1$ the cubic $Q(\mu, \cdot)$ has three distinct real roots, one negative and two positive, which we denote $y_1(\mu) < y_2(\mu)$.

Theorem 1. *Let $0 < \mu \leq 1$.*

(a) *On each of $\mathcal{A}_+$ and $\mathcal{A}_-$ the function P has exactly one critical point, and it is the minimum of P on that arc. Denote the two minima by $P_+(\mu)$ and $P_-(\mu)$.*

(b) *$P_+(\mu)^2$ and $P_-(\mu)^2$ are roots of $Q(\mu, \cdot)$. For $\mu < 1$, $P_-(\mu)^2 = y_1(\mu)$ and $P_+(\mu)^2 = y_2(\mu)$, so $P_-(\mu) < P_+(\mu)$; for $\mu = 1$, $P_+ = P_- = \sqrt{2}$.*

(c) *The least value of P over the collapsing configurations, $P_-(\mu)$, is strictly increasing on $(0, 1]$, and $P_-(\mu) \rightarrow \sqrt{3}/2$ as $\mu \rightarrow 0^+$.*

Proof. (a) A direct computation from (11) gives

$$\frac{dP}{d\theta} = -\frac{K(C)}{2\mu M(C)^2 \sin^2\theta}, \quad (14)$$

where

$$K(C) = 4(1 - \mu)C^3 + 4(2\mu^2 - \mu + 2)C^2 + 2(1 - \mu)^3C - (2\mu^4 + 7\mu^3 + 6\mu^2 + 7\mu + 2). \quad (15)$$

As θ runs over $\mathcal{A}_+$, C decreases monotonically from $\sqrt{R}$ to $C_0 = (\mu - 1)/2$; over $\mathcal{A}_-$ it increases from $-\sqrt{R}$ to C_0 . The critical points on the two arcs therefore correspond to the roots of K in $(C_0, \sqrt{R})$ and in $(-\sqrt{R}, C_0)$. Now $K(\pm\sqrt{R}) = \pm\sqrt{R}N(\pm\sqrt{R})M(\pm\sqrt{R})/R$, which is positive because $M(\sqrt{R}) > 0 > M(-\sqrt{R})$, and $K(C_0) = -3(1 + \mu)^4/2 < 0$. So K has a root in each interval. For $\mu < 1$, K is a cubic with positive leading coefficient, so it also has a root below $-\sqrt{R}$, and each interval contains exactly one root. For $\mu = 1$, $K = 12C^2 - 24$, with one root in each of $(-\sqrt{3}, 0)$ and $(0, \sqrt{3})$. The function P is differentiable on each arc, and at the ends of each arc $M(C) \sin \theta \rightarrow 0$ while $N > 0$, so $P \rightarrow +\infty$; hence the single critical point is the minimum.

(b) At a critical point $K(C) = 0$, and since $R \sin^2 \theta = R - C^2$, the number $y = P^2$ satisfies $4\mu^2 y(R - C^2)M(C)^2 = N(C)^2$. The resultant of these two polynomials with respect to C is $-48\mu^4(1 + \mu)^8 Q(\mu, y)$, so $P_{\pm}(\mu)^2$ are roots of $Q(\mu, \cdot)$. For $\mu = 1$, $Q(1, y) = 6912(y - 2)^2(4y + 1)$, so $P_{\pm}(1) = \sqrt{2}$. For $0 < \mu < 1$ both are positive roots, hence each lies in $\{y_1(\mu), y_2(\mu)\}$. The three roots of K are simple, so $P_+(\mu)$ and $P_-(\mu)$ depend continuously on μ , and so do $y_1(\mu) < y_2(\mu)$. By connectedness each of P_+^2 and P_-^2 coincides with the same y_i on all of $(0, 1)$. At $\mu = 1/2$, $P_- = 1.0647\dots$ and $P_+ = 2.2038\dots$ (Proposition 1, whose proof uses only (a) and the first part of (b)), so $P_-^2 = y_1$ and $P_+^2 = y_2$.

(c) The roots $y_i(\mu)$ are simple for $0 < \mu < 1$ and hence differentiable, with $y'_i = -(\partial Q / \partial \mu) / (\partial Q / \partial y)$. A zero of y'_1 at some μ would be a common root of $Q(\mu, \cdot)$ and $\partial Q(\mu, \cdot) / \partial \mu$, but their resultant with respect to y ,

$$7044820107264 \mu^7 (\mu - 1)^3 (\mu + 1)^7 (\mu + 2)^3 (2\mu + 1)^3 R^6 AB^3, \quad (16)$$

where $A = 4\mu^6 + 12\mu^5 + 21\mu^4 + 22\mu^3 + 21\mu^2 + 12\mu + 4$, has no zero in $(0, 1)$. So y_1 is strictly monotone on $(0, 1)$. The leading coefficient of $Q(\mu, \cdot)$ does not vanish at $\mu = 1$, so the roots stay bounded as $\mu \rightarrow 1^-$, and y_1 tends to a nonnegative root of $Q(1, \cdot)$, which is 2. Since $y_1(1/2) = 1.1335\dots < 2$, y_1 is increasing. As $\mu \rightarrow 0^+$ it therefore decreases to a limit $L \geq 0$, which is a root of $Q(0, y) = -16(4y - 3)$, so $L = 3/4$. $\square$

Corollary 1. *Every collapse of three point vortices has $|\omega_0| t_c > \sqrt{3}/2$, and for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is a collapse with $|\omega_0| t_c < \sqrt{3}/2 + \varepsilon$. Equivalently, each vortex travels more than twice its initial distance from the collision point, and the factor 2 is sharp.*

Proof. By the normalization (4) and Theorem 1, $P \geq P_-(\mu) > \sqrt{3}/2$, and $P_-(\mu) \rightarrow \sqrt{3}/2$ as $\mu \rightarrow 0^+$. The path length is $r_0 \sqrt{1 + 4P^2} > 2r_0$, and no vortex starts at the collision point, since z_1, z_2 and z_3 in (5) never vanish. $\square$

The two minima are shown in Figure 1.

3.3. The ratio $\mu = 1/2$

For $\Gamma = (1, 1/2, -1/3)$ we have $R = 7/4$ and $\cos \theta_0 = -\sqrt{7}/14$, and (11) becomes

$$P(\theta) = \frac{14 \sin^2 \theta + 6\sqrt{7} \cos \theta + 21}{2(14 \cos \theta + \sqrt{7}) \sin \theta}. \quad (17)$$

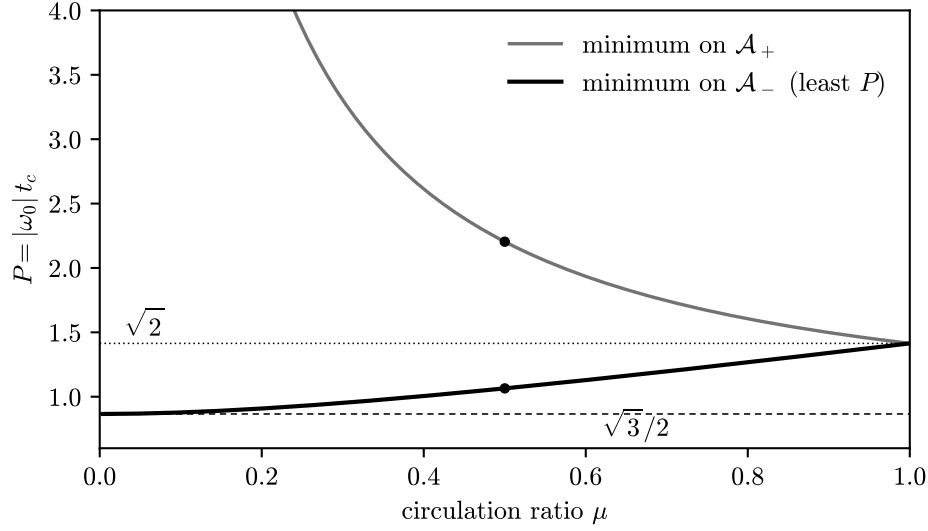


Figure 1: The minima $P_-(\mu)$ and $P_+(\mu)$ of $P = |\omega_0| t_c$ on the two collapsing arcs, as functions of the circulation ratio μ . The dots mark $\mu = 1/2$ (Proposition 1). As $\mu \rightarrow 0$, P_- tends to $\sqrt{3}/2$ and P_+ grows without bound.

Proposition 1. Let $X = 245351/5201^{3/2}$ and $S = 7\sqrt{5201}/162$. For $\mu = 1/2$,

$$P_- = \sqrt{\frac{605}{324} + S \cos\left(\frac{1}{3} \arccos X - \frac{2\pi}{3}\right)} = 1.0647059762712043..., \quad (18)$$

$$P_+ = \sqrt{\frac{605}{324} + S \cos\left(\frac{1}{3} \arccos X\right)} = 2.2038550160361327..., \quad (19)$$

attained at $\cos \theta = -0.9243893679...$ and $\cos \theta = 0.6739838839...$ respectively. Both are roots of the polynomial $8748\xi^6 - 49005\xi^4 + 27794\xi^2 + 18723$, which is irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$ and whose real roots are exactly these two numbers and their negatives.

Proof. Here $16Q(1/2, \xi^2) = 8748\xi^6 - 49005\xi^4 + 27794\xi^2 + 18723$, and by Theorem 1(b) the squares of both minima are roots of this polynomial. As a cubic in $q = \xi^2$ it is irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$ and has positive discriminant, so its roots are real and are given by the trigonometric solution of the cubic, $q_k = 605/324 + S \cos(1/3 \arccos X - 2\pi k/3)$, $k = 0, 1, 2$, with $q_0 \approx 4.856977$, $q_1 \approx 1.133599$ and $q_2 \approx -0.388724$. The critical points are the roots of K in the two intervals of the proof of Theorem 1(a); with $C = (\sqrt{7}/2) \cos \theta$ they are at the stated values of $\cos \theta$. Evaluating (11) there gives $P_- = \sqrt{q_1}$ and $P_+ = \sqrt{q_0}$; the numerical values differ from these square roots by less than 10^{-50} , far less than the separation of the roots. $\square$

Remark 1. The two minima are conjugate algebraic numbers of degree six. Since the cubic in q is irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$ and has three real roots, none of its roots is expressible by real radicals (casus irreducibilis), and therefore neither minimum is. The same holds for every rational $\mu = a/b \in (0, 1)$ with $b \leq 30$: for each of these 277 values, $Q(\mu, \xi^2)$ is irreducible over $\mathbb{Q}$.

Remark 2. For $\mu = 1$, that is $\Gamma = (1, 1, -1/2)$, the zero-impulse circle is $|w - 1/2| = \sqrt{3}/2$. With $w = 1/2 + (\sqrt{3}/2)e^{i\beta}$, $z_1 = 0$ and $z_2 = 1$, the same computation gives $P = (3 - \cos 2\beta)/(2 \sin 2\beta)$ on the collapsing arcs $0 < \beta < \pi/2$ and $\pi < \beta < 3\pi/2$, which are exchanged by interchanging the

two equal vortices ($w \rightarrow 1 - w$). Since P has period π in β , Lemma 1 applies on both arcs and gives $P \geq \sqrt{2}$, with equality if and only if $\cos 2\beta = 1/3$, in agreement with Theorem 1. This expression for P is a specialization and reparametrization of Gröbli's spiral coefficient [7, Sect. 10].

Remark 3. Interchanging the first two vortices and multiplying the circulations by $1/\mu$ maps the family with ratio μ onto the family with ratio $1/\mu$ and exchanges the two orientations, so the arc minima satisfy $P_+(\mu) = P_-(1/\mu)$. For $\mu > 1$ the smaller minimum is therefore attained on $\mathcal{A}_+$.

4. Two concentric regular polygons

In this section θ denotes the relative rotation of two rings. Let $n \geq 2$ and $\varepsilon = e^{2\pi i/n}$, and place vortices of circulation $x > 0$ at $z\varepsilon^k$ and vortices of circulation -1 at $\zeta\varepsilon^k$, $k = 0, \dots, n-1$. The motion preserves this symmetry, the center of vorticity is the origin, and, since $\sum_{k=1}^{n-1} (1 - \varepsilon^k)^{-1} = (n-1)/2$ and $\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} (z - \zeta\varepsilon^k)^{-1} = nz^{n-1}/(z^n - \zeta^n)$, (1) reduces to [2, Eq. (3)]

$$\bar{\dot{z}} = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left(\frac{x(n-1)}{2z} - \frac{nz^{n-1}}{z^n - \zeta^n} \right), \quad \bar{\dot{\zeta}} = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left(-\frac{n-1}{2\zeta} + \frac{xn\zeta^{n-1}}{\zeta^n - z^n} \right). \quad (20)$$

A collapse requires the angular impulse $n(x|z|^2 - |\zeta|^2)$ to vanish, and after a rotation and a dilation we take $z = 1$ and $\zeta = \sqrt{x}e^{i\theta}$. The motion is self-similar exactly when $\dot{z}/z = \dot{\zeta}/\zeta$. Writing $v = \zeta^n$, (20) gives

$$\bar{\dot{z}}/z = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left(\frac{x(n-1)}{2} - \frac{n}{1-v} \right), \quad \bar{\dot{\zeta}}/\zeta = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \left(-\frac{n-1}{2x} - \frac{nv}{1-v} \right), \quad (21)$$

and these are equal if and only if

$$(n-1)x^2 - 2nx + (n-1) = 0. \quad (22)$$

This is the circulation condition of Koiller et al. [8, Sect. 11]. It does not involve θ because it is the classical condition $\sum_{i < j} \Gamma_i \Gamma_j = 0$ for the $2n$ vortices, whose left side here equals $(n/2)((n-1)x^2 - 2nx + (n-1))$. Its roots are x_n and $1/x_n$, where

$$x_n = \frac{n + \sqrt{2n-1}}{n-1} = e^\eta, \quad \cosh \eta = \frac{n}{n-1}. \quad (23)$$

The root $1/x_n$ gives the same family with the two rings interchanged, as one sees by multiplying the circulations by $-x_n$ and reflecting the configuration, so we take $x = x_n$. Then every θ gives a self-similar motion. Let $\rho = x_n^{n/2} = e^{n\eta/2} > 1$ and $\alpha = n\theta$, so that $v = \rho e^{i\alpha}$. The common value of $\bar{\kappa}$ is $S/(2\pi i)$ with $S = x_n(n-1)/2 - n/(1-v)$, so $\kappa = (\text{Im } S + i \text{Re } S)/(2\pi)$, and since $\text{Im}(1-v)^{-1} = \rho \sin \alpha / |1-v|^2$,

$$\text{Re } \kappa = -\frac{n\rho \sin \alpha}{2\pi |1-v|^2}. \quad (24)$$

The configuration therefore collapses exactly when $\sin n\theta > 0$, that is, for $0 < \theta < \pi/n$ modulo $2\pi/n$. Using $|1-v|^2 = 1 - 2\rho \cos \alpha + \rho^2$ one finds

$$\frac{|1-v|^2 \text{Re } S}{\rho} = K_n - ((n-1)x_n - n) \cos \alpha, \quad K_n = \frac{(n-1)x_n(\rho + \rho^{-1})}{2} - \frac{n}{\rho}. \quad (25)$$

Here $(n-1)x_n - n = \sqrt{2n-1}$, and substituting $n = (n-1) \cosh \eta$ in n/ρ gives $K_n = (n-1) \sinh((n+2)\eta/2)$. Moreover

$$K_n - \sqrt{2n-1} = \frac{(n-1)x_n(\rho^{1/2} - \rho^{-1/2})^2}{2} + n(1 - \rho^{-1}) > 0, \quad (26)$$

so $\operatorname{Re} S > 0$, and (2) gives

$$P = \frac{K_n - \sqrt{2n-1} \cos n\theta}{2n \sin n\theta}, \quad 0 < n\theta < \pi. \quad (27)$$

The collapse rate and the rotation rate as functions of the relative angle are given by Koiller et al. [8, Sect. 11]; (27) writes their ratio in closed form.

Proposition 2. *For $n \geq 2$ the collapsing configurations of two concentric regular n -gons with circulations x_n and -1 satisfy*

$$P \geq F_n = \frac{\sqrt{K_n^2 - (2n-1)}}{2n}, \quad (28)$$

with equality if and only if $\cos n\theta = \sqrt{2n-1}/K_n$.

Proof. Apply Lemma 1 to (27) with $a = K_n$ and $b = \sqrt{2n-1}$. □

For small n the constants are as follows.

n	x_n	K_n	F_n	$\cos n\theta$ at the minimum
2	$2 + \sqrt{3}$	$4\sqrt{3}$	$3\sqrt{5}/4$	$1/4$
3	$(3 + \sqrt{5})/2$	11	$\sqrt{29}/3$	$\sqrt{5}/11$
4	$(4 + \sqrt{7})/3$	$55\sqrt{7}/9$	$\sqrt{322}/9$	$9/55$
5	2	$127\sqrt{2}/8$	$\sqrt{31682}/80$	$12\sqrt{2}/127$

For $n = 2$ the configuration is a parallelogram of four vortices; four-vortex collapse is treated by Novikov and Sedov [12, Sect. 4]. The ratio x_n is rational exactly when $2n-1$ is a perfect square, and $n = 5$ is the smallest such n . There $x_5 = 2$ and

$$P = \frac{127\sqrt{2} - 24 \cos 5\theta}{80 \sin 5\theta} \geq \frac{\sqrt{31682}}{80} = 2.2249297741726591\dots \quad (29)$$

5. Numerical verification

The results were checked numerically as summarized in Table 1. Except where the table says otherwise, the checks evaluate the Biot–Savart velocities (1) directly for configurations built independently of (5) (two vortices fixed and the third moved around the zero-impulse circle), test self-similarity by comparing $\dot{z}_j/(z_j - z_c)$ across all vortices, and obtain P from (2). Differences at the level of the working precision are reported as such. The algebraic steps in the proofs were verified in exact arithmetic (SymPy): Lemma 2 for all three vortices, (15), the resultant in the proof of Theorem 1(b), the discriminant and the resultant in the proof of Theorem 1(c), the irreducibility of Q and of the 277 specializations in Remark 1, Proposition 1, and the identities of Section 4.

Check	Result
Lemma 2 against the Biot–Savart velocities of all three vortices at the positions (5), 36 random pairs (μ, θ) , 50 digits	relative difference $\leq 10^{-50}$
Arc minima by direct minimization of P , 26 values of $\mu \in (0, 1]$ at 30 digits and 12 rational values at 50 digits	agree with the roots of $Q(\mu, \cdot)$ to 6×10^{-25} and 5×10^{-45}
$\mu = 1/2$: the three quotients over 4000 shapes on the zero-impulse circle, 60 digits	equal to working precision; 2000 of the 4000 shapes collapse
$\mu = 1/2$: local minima of P over the collapsing shapes, located numerically	two, equal to the values of Proposition 1 to working precision
$\mu = 1/2$: formula for $P(\theta)$ against direct evaluation at the positions (5), 399 interior points of each arc	relative difference $\leq 10^{-59}$
$\mu = 1/2$: integration of (1) from the minimizing configuration on $\mathcal{A}_-$ (Taylor method, 30 digits)	$ z_j - z_c ^2$ follows $1 - t/t_c$ to working precision up to $t = 0.9 t_c$
Two rings, $n = 2, \dots, 8$: P from (1) against (27) over the collapsing range, and its numerical minimum against F_n , 60 digits	relative difference $\leq 3 \times 10^{-58}$; minima agree to 2×10^{-60}

Table 1: Numerical checks of the results.

6. Discussion

Lemma 2 is a special case of the rates of Gröbli [7] and Aref [3], and Theorem 1 concerns their minimization. When the two circulations of the same sign differ, $\mu < 1$, the two orientations of the triangle are not equivalent and the minima on the two arcs differ, so a minimization restricted to one orientation finds only one of them. The infimum $\sqrt{3}/2$ of Corollary 1 is approached only as $\mu \rightarrow 0$ and is not attained.

Leoncini, Kuznetsov and Zaslavsky [10] analyze the motion near collapse when two of the vortices are identical. Tavantzis and Ting [14] describe, for $\sum_{j < k} \Gamma_j \Gamma_k = 0$, the contracting and the expanding self-similar solutions as one-parameter families and discuss their stability. Krishnamurthy and Stremler [9] relate the interior angles of the triangle, the circulation ratios, the energy, the collapse time and the distance traveled before collapse. Since that distance is $\sqrt{1 + 4P^2}$ times the initial distance from the collision point, Corollary 1 shows that it always exceeds twice the initial distance and that the factor 2 cannot be improved.

For two rings, Aref [2] derived the reduced equations (20) for arbitrary circulations and analyzed equal and opposite circulations, $x = 1$, which do not satisfy (22). Koiller et al. [8] found the collapsing configurations and their rates; (27) writes the ratio of these rates in closed form, and Proposition 2 gives its minimum over the relative rotation. O’Neil [13] proves that for generic circulations three concentric rings have finitely many relative equilibria and collapse configurations. Demina and Kudryashov [5] study relative equilibria, collapse and scattering of point vortices with arbitrary circulations and give explicit double-ring configurations formed by two regular polygons.

We have not found the minimal values of Theorem 1 and Propositions 1 and 2, or the bound of Corollary 1, stated in the literature.

Data availability. The programs used for the checks in Section 5 and for Figure 1, and their output, are in the directory `research/` of the repository <https://github.com/SharpMeow/GENChase>.

This work was prepared with AI assistance. The author takes full responsibility for its content.

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